What's Wrong With Science?

Who Do You Trust?

Mistrust and the politicization of science



Session 6 · Professor David Gresham · Fall 2026

Guest: Pat Egan, Professor of Politics and Public Policy, NYU



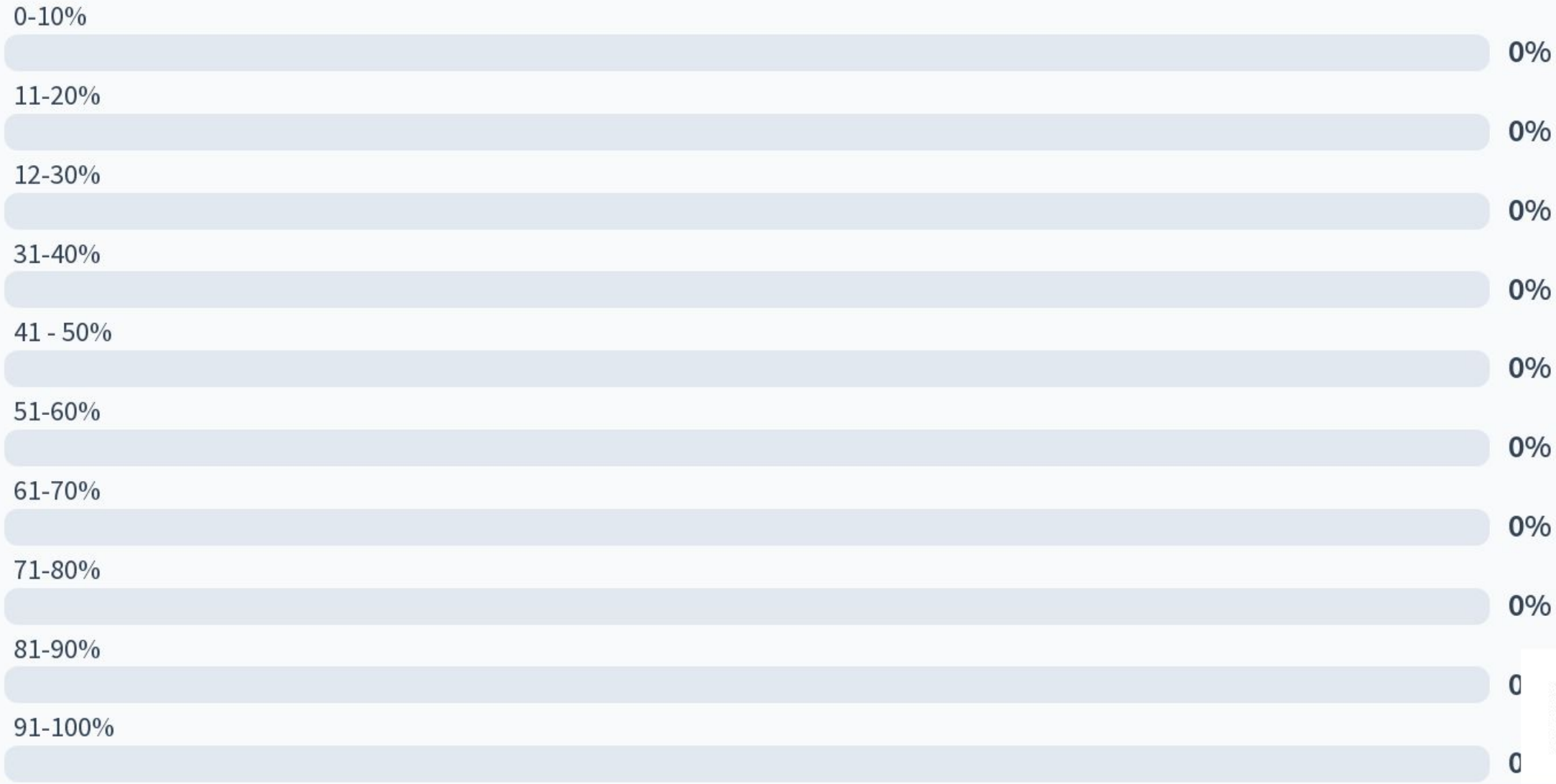
Professor Pat Egan



? / 100

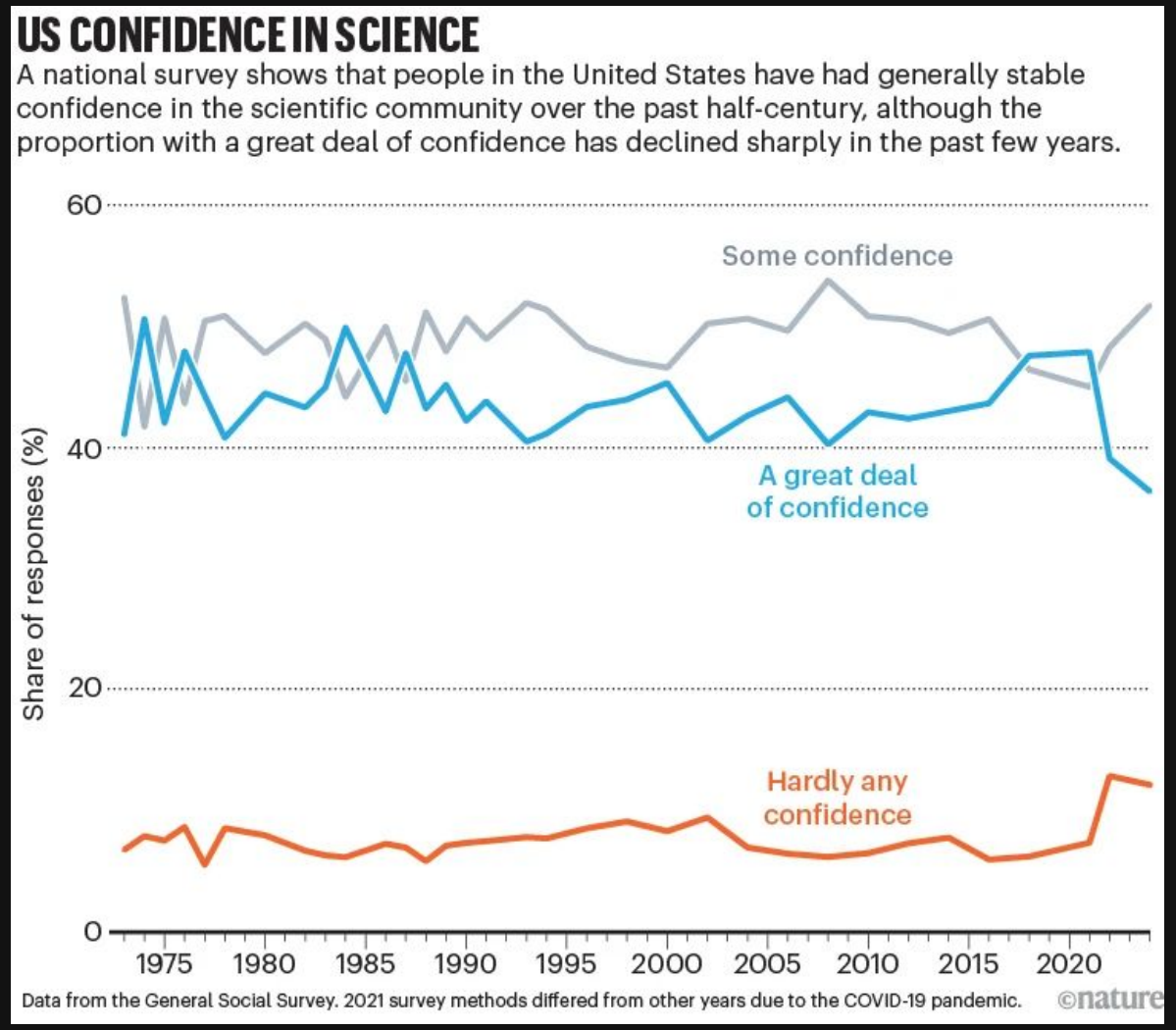
What percentage of Americans have at least a fair amount of confidence that scientists act in the public’s best interests?

What percentage of Americans trust science?



Start the presentation to see live content. For screen share software, share the entire screen. Get help at **pollev.com/app**

“Trust in science has collapsed” — or has it?



Source: Pearson, “Have people stopped trusting science? The data tell a surprising story,” Nature 655, 22–25 (2026)

“Trust in science has collapsed” — or has it?

40%

of people in the UK think the science information they hear is “generally true”

UKRI, Public Attitudes to Science 2025

70%

in a 16-country poll believe at least one false or unproven health claim (e.g. vaccine risks outweigh benefits)

Edelman Trust Barometer, 2026

“Fallen significantly”

“Over the last 5 years, confidence that scientists act in the best interests of the public has fallen significantly.”

Executive order, President Trump, 2025

Source: Pearson, “Have people stopped trusting science? The data tell a surprising story,” Nature 655, 22–25 (2026)

What do we mean by "trust" in science?

Nobody has responded yet.

Hang tight! Responses are coming in.

Start the presentation to see live content. For screen share software, share the entire screen. Get help at **pollev.com/app**

Four dimensions of trust measured

Competence

Are scientists qualified?

Integrity

Are they honest?

Benevolence

Do they care about people like me?

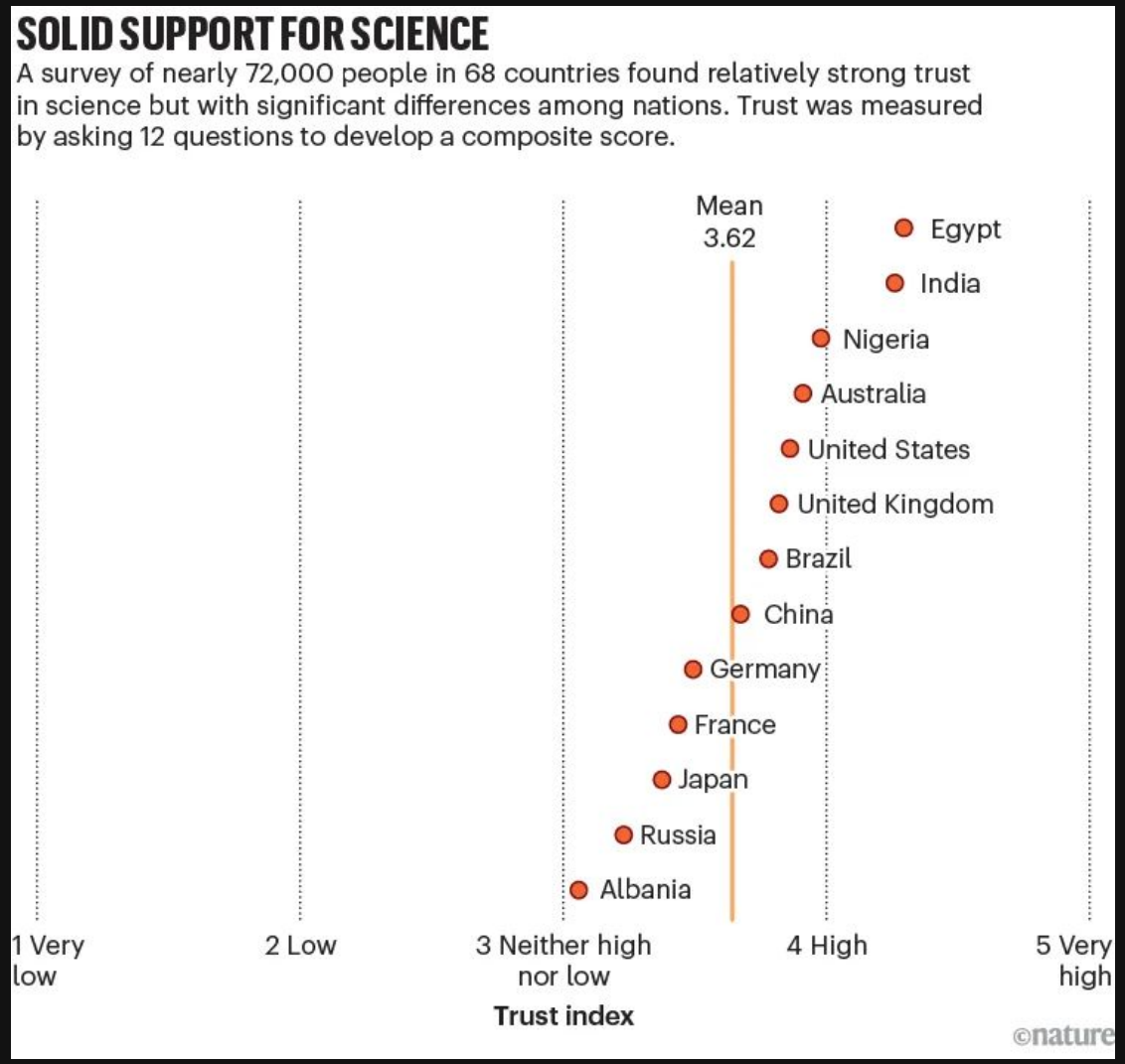
Openness

Do they listen? (lowest-rated)

TISP survey · nearly 72,000 people · 68 countries · 2022–23

Sources: Cologna, Mede et al., Nature Human Behaviour 9, 713–730 (2025); Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026)

Globally, trust in scientists is moderately high



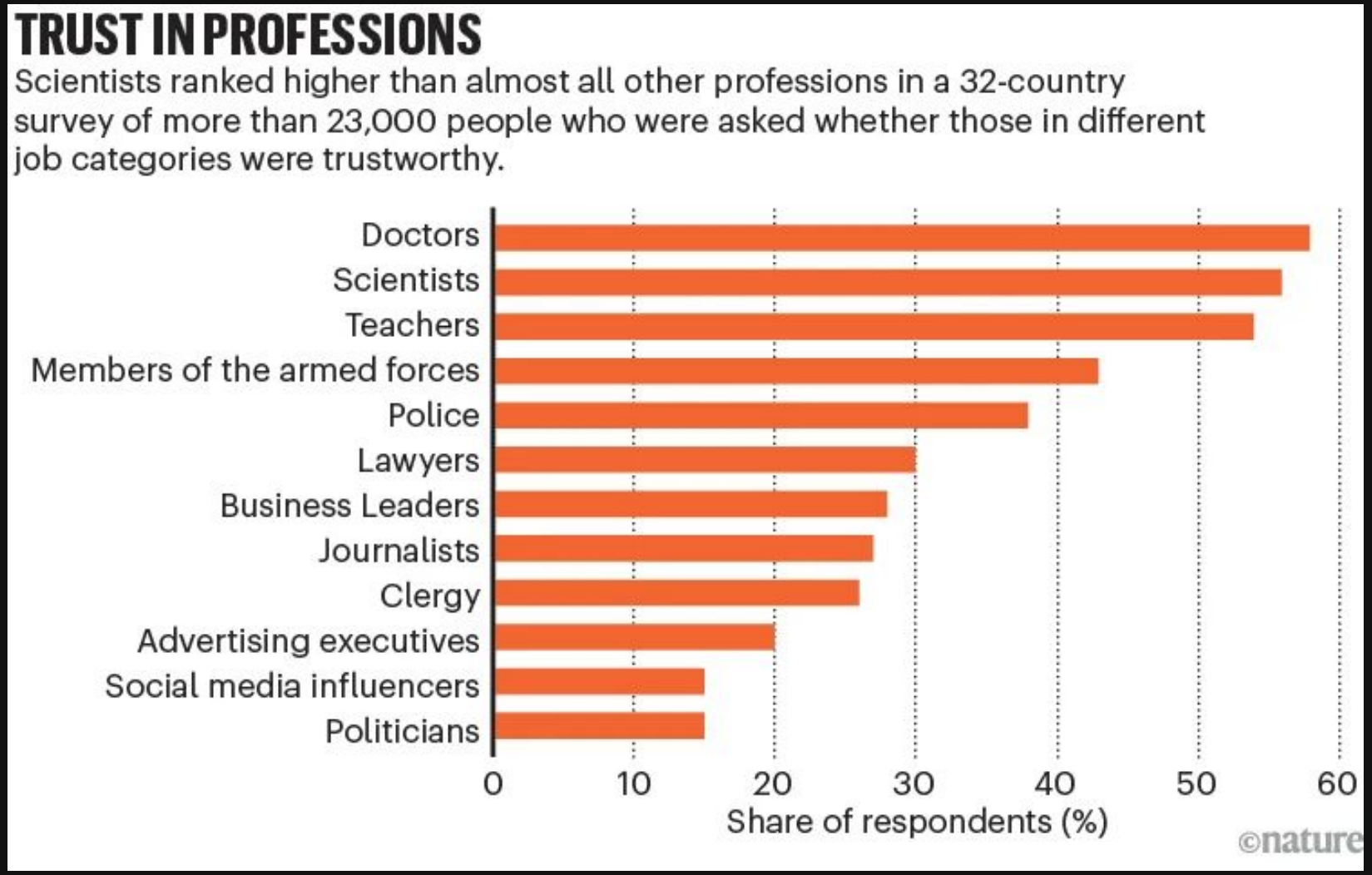
3.6

out of 5: average trust in scientists

TISP survey · nearly 72,000 people · 68 countries · 2022–23

Sources: Cologna, Mede et al., Nature Human Behaviour 9, 713–730 (2025); Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026)

Scientists are among the most trusted professions



Sources: Edelman Trust Barometer 2026 Global Report (survey 2025); Ipsos Global Trustworthiness Index 2024; both as reported in Nature 655 (2026)

But “a lot” of trust has collapsed

Britain: share of respondents who trust science “a lot”



84% still have at least some trust.
The shift is from enthusiasm to wariness

Sources: Wellcome & More in Common, Britain Talks Trust in Science (2026); Henderson, Nature 655, 9 (2026); Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026)

In the US, trust in science has declined

Poll answer

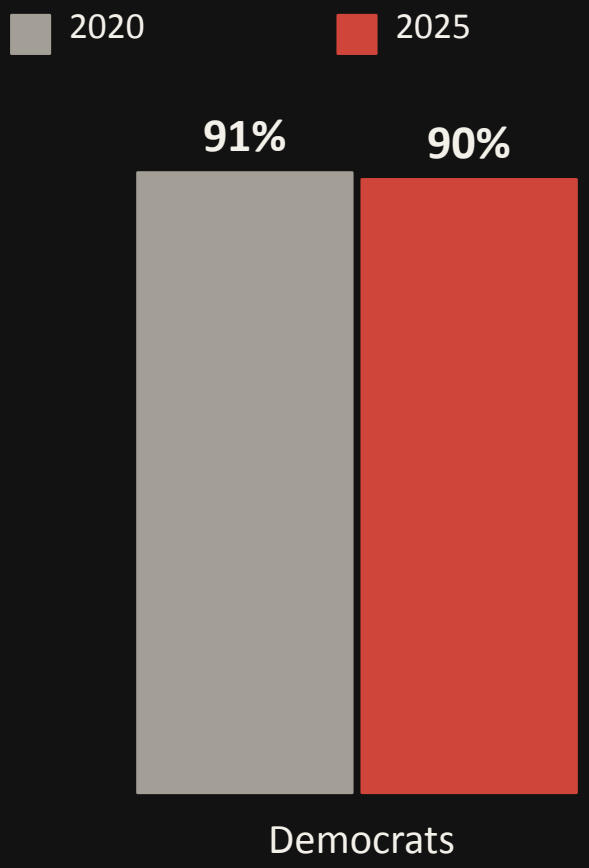
77%

of all US adults (down from 87% in April 2020)

Sources: Pew Research Center (Jan 2026), as reported in Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026); GSS via Schulman et al., Public Opinion Quarterly 89 (2025)

In the US, trust in science has declined

Are you confident that scientists act in the public's interest (Pew)



Poll answer

77%

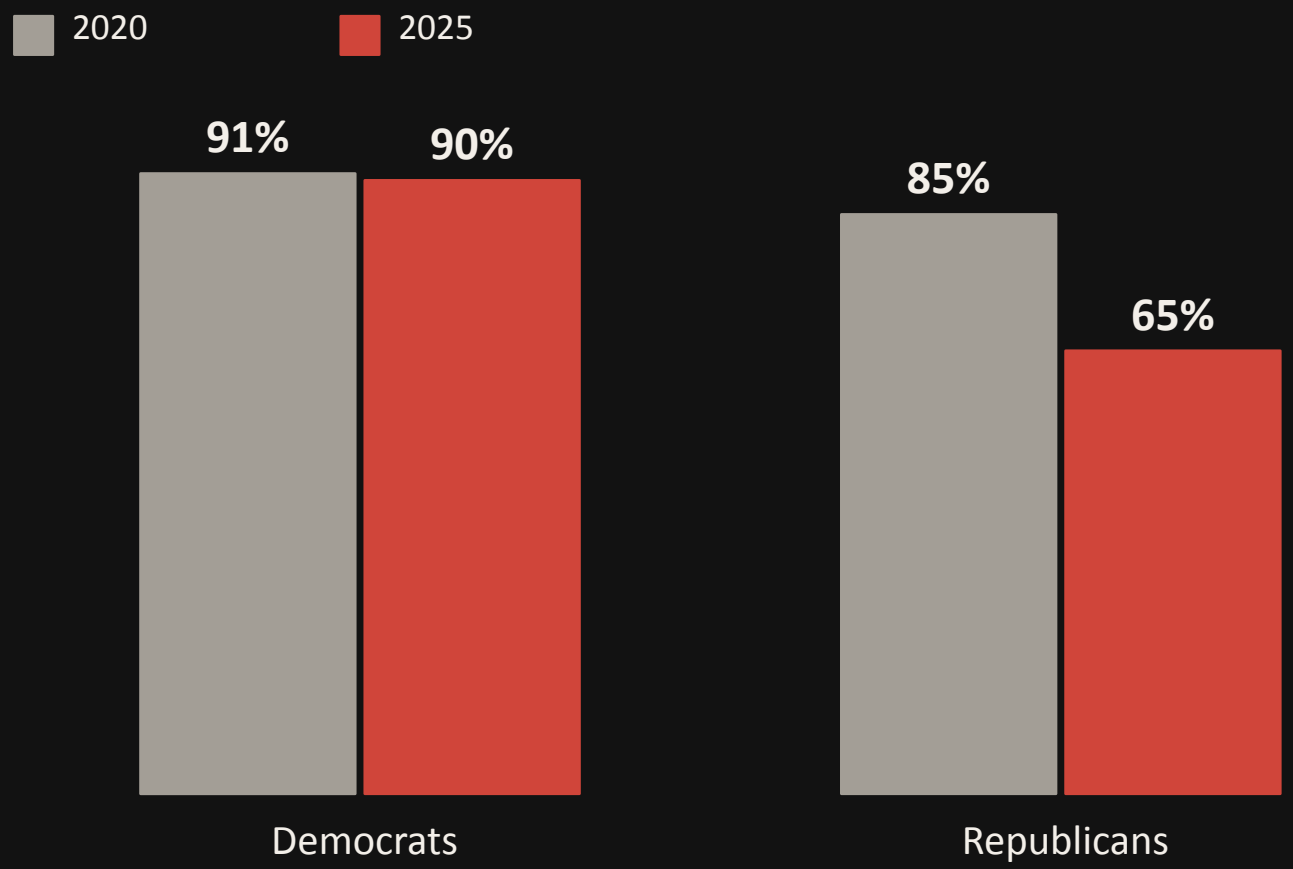
of all US adults (down from 87% in April 2020)

The General Social Survey (1973–2024) shows the partisan gap opening around 2005–10, long before COVID. The pandemic widened it.

Sources: Pew Research Center (Jan 2026), as reported in Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026); GSS via Schulman et al., Public Opinion Quarterly 89 (2025)

In the US, trust has split along party lines

Are you confident that scientists act in the public's interest (Pew)



Poll answer

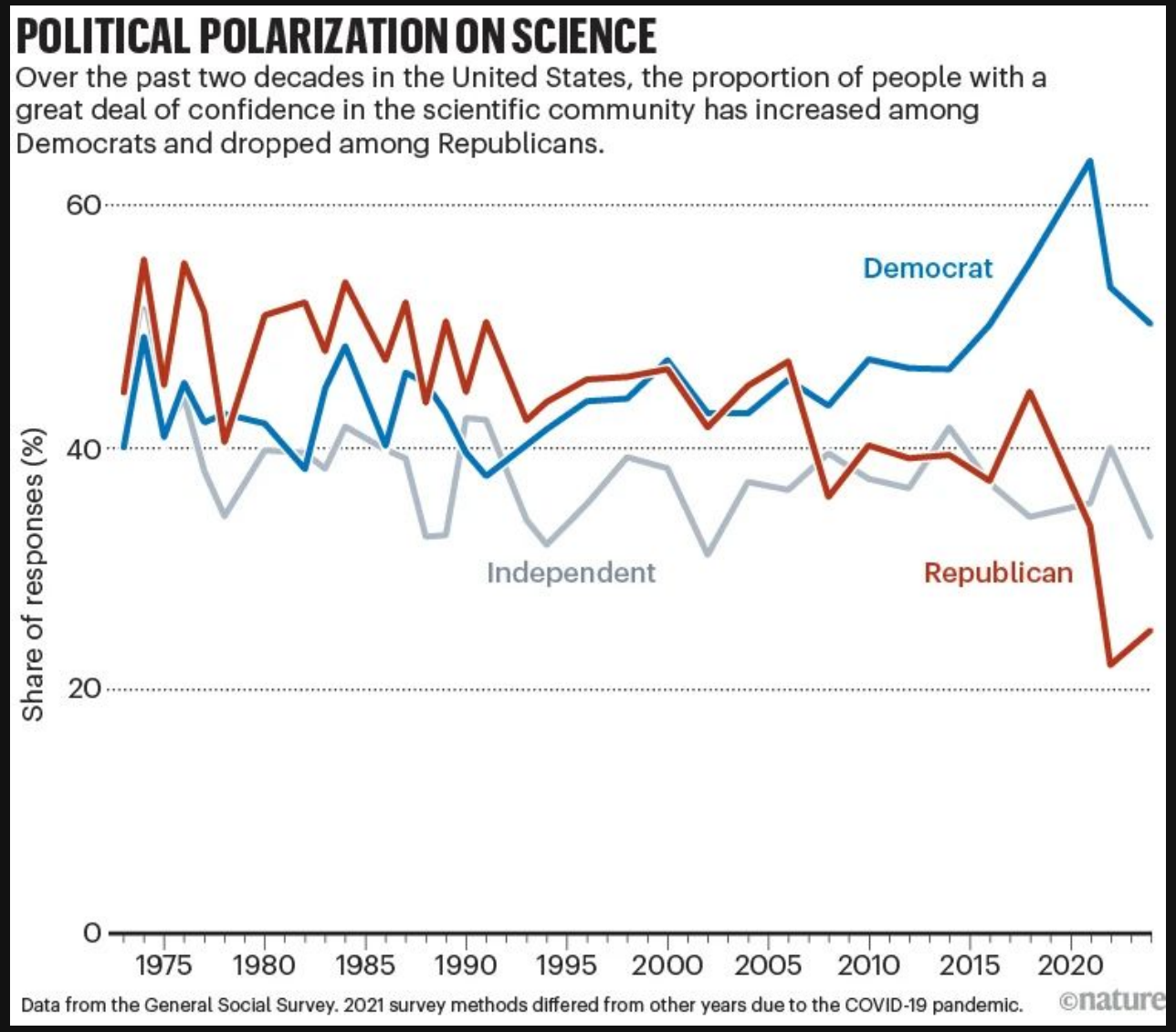
77%

of all US adults (down from 87% in April 2020)

The General Social Survey (1973–2024) shows the partisan gap opening around 2005–10, long before COVID. The pandemic widened it.

Sources: Pew Research Center (Jan 2026), as reported in Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026); GSS via Schulman et al., Public Opinion Quarterly 89 (2025)

In the US, trust has split along party lines



How did science become partisan?



Why has science become partisan?

Nobody has responded yet.

Hang tight! Responses are coming in.

Start the presentation to see live content. For screen share software, share the entire screen. Get help at **pollev.com/app**

How did science become partisan?

Re-sorting

Groups with long-standing lower trust (especially religious Americans) moved to the Republicans; degree-holders moved to the Democrats. “They re-sorted.” — James Druckman

Political mobilization

From the mid-1990s, politicians found they could mobilize resentment of higher education, casting scientists as an out-of-touch elite: “making them the villains.” — Gordon Gauchat

The pandemic accelerant

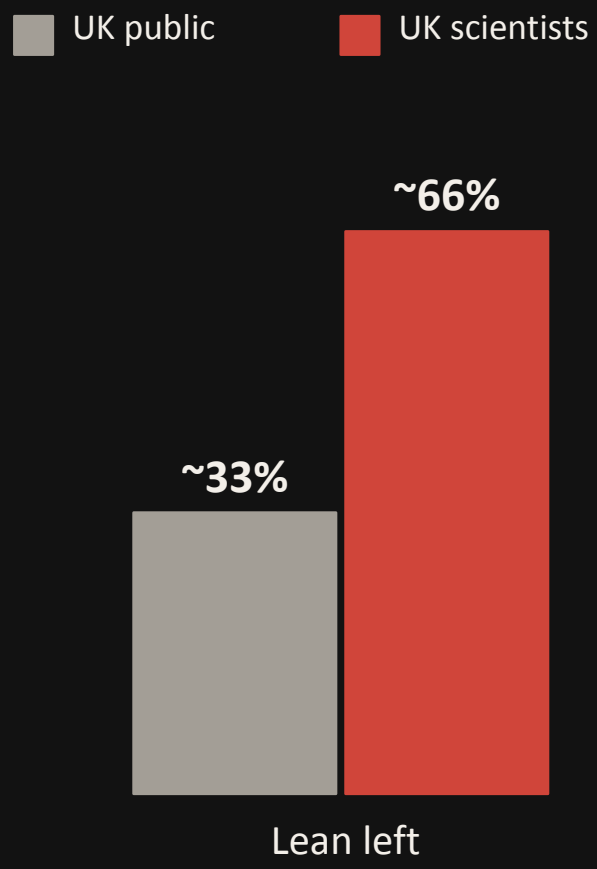
Masks, lockdowns, mandates. People often objected to the policies that flowed from science rather than the science itself. — Kathleen Hall Jamieson

Distrust of institutions

Distrust now justifies cuts: “this whole institution is not trustworthy.”

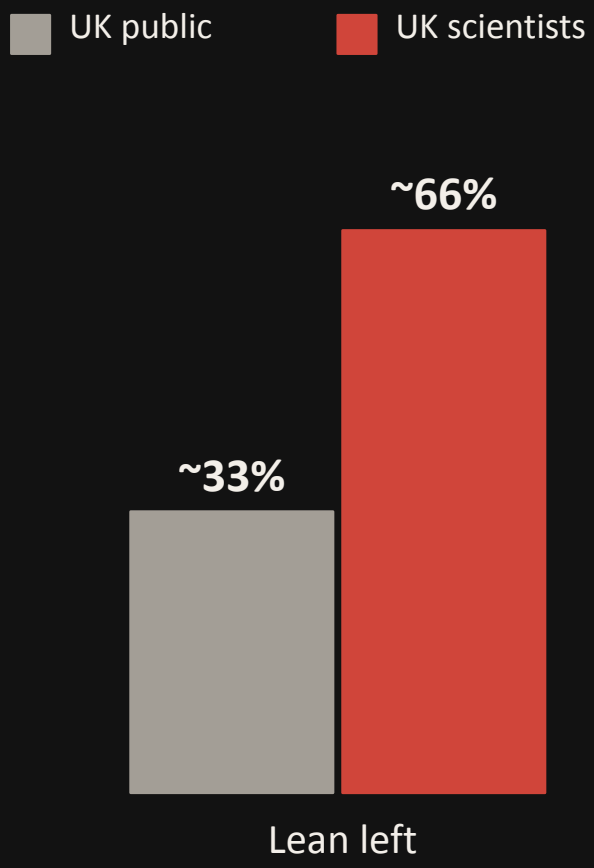
Source: Pearson, Nature 655, 22–25 (2026); Druckman et al., Nature Human Behaviour 10, 476–491 (2026)

Scientists are not politically representative



Source: Henderson (Wellcome), "Scientists should recognize their own political biases to build public trust," Nature 655, 9 (2026)

Scientists are not politically representative



~40%

of scientists polled are “progressive activists,” vs 12% of the public

People who see bias in science are twice as likely to say it leans left as right

Small sample: 142 UK scientists.

Source: Henderson (Wellcome), “Scientists should recognize their own political biases to build public trust,” Nature 655, 9 (2026)

Three ways scientists make polarization worse

1

Assuming our values are shared

What feels normal in a lab or a university is not what everyone believes.

Assumed agreement sounds arrogant and out of touch.

2

Dressing values as facts

Science can define a problem and test solutions. It cannot decide the trade-off between fairness, cost, liberty and security.

“Follow the science” can be overreach.

3

Science as a team badge

If respect for science is bundled with a political identity, people may reject the science along with the politics.

Source: Henderson, Nature 655, 9 (2026)

Is this statement informed by evidence, values, or both?

A The MMR vaccine does not cause autism.

B Human activity is the main cause of recent global warming.

C Schools should have stayed closed for the 2020–21 school year.

D A carbon tax is the best way to cut emissions.

E Adults should be free to buy raw milk.



For each statement, vote:

Evidence
Values
Both

Is this statement informed by evidence, values, or both?

A The MMR vaccine does not cause autism.

B Human activity is the main cause of recent global warming.

C Schools should have stayed closed for the 2020–21 school year.

D A carbon tax is the best way to cut emissions.

E Adults should be free to buy raw milk.

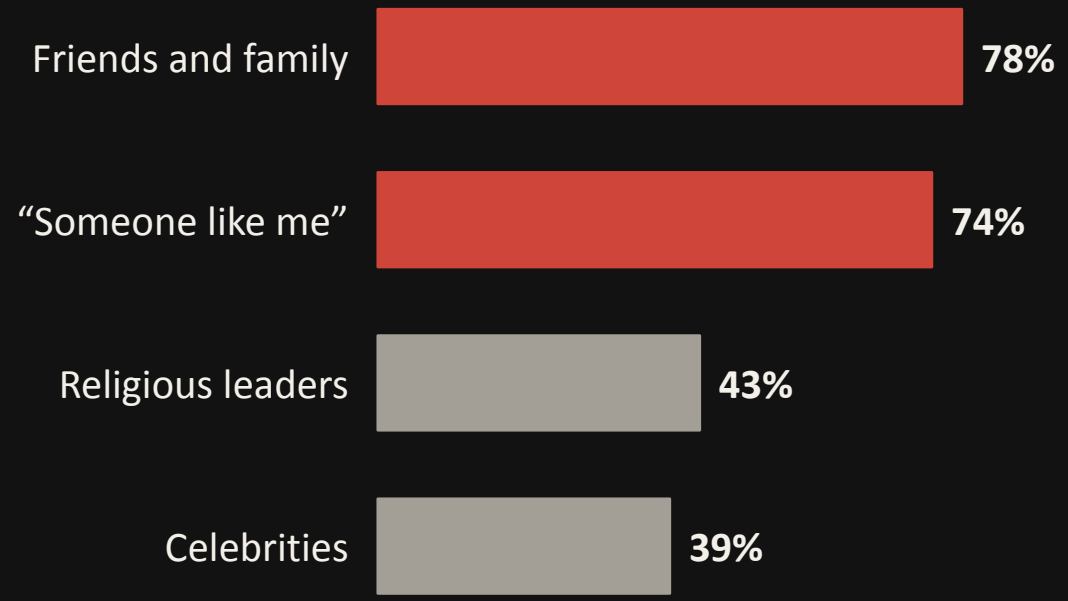


For each statement, vote:

Evidence (one hand up)
Values (two hands up)
Both (Stand up)

The problem may be influence, not trust

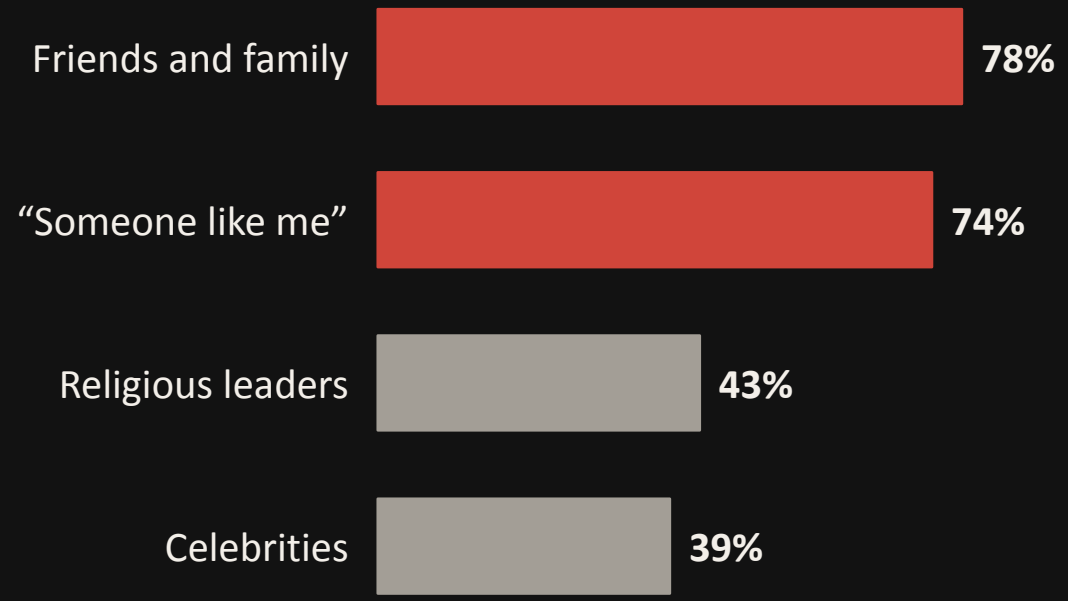
Who people trust for information (Edelman 2024)



Sources: Larson & Bersoff, Nature 640, 314–317 (2025); Edelman Trust Barometer 2024–25; TISP (Mede et al. 2025) in Pearson, Nature 655 (2026)

The problem may be influence, not trust

Who people trust for information (Edelman 2024)



“Sometimes a sample of one, when you know that person, is more powerful emotionally, if not statistically, than a sample of 10,000.”

Sources: Larson & Bersoff, Nature 640, 314–317 (2025); Edelman Trust Barometer 2024–25; TISP (Mede et al. 2025) in Pearson, Nature 655 (2026)

An official website of the United States government Here's how you know

Autism and Vaccines

For Everyone

JULY 22, 2026

KEY POINTS

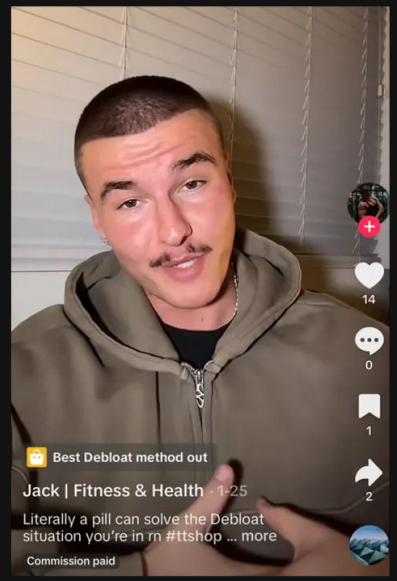
- The claim "vaccines do not cause autism" is not an evidence-based claim because studies have not ruled out the possibility that infant vaccines cause autism.
- Studies supporting a link have been ignored by health authorities.
- HHS has launched a comprehensive assessment of the causes of autism, including investigations on plausible biologic mechanisms and potential causal links.

Background

It is critical to address questions the American people have about the cause of autism to ensure public health guidance is adequately responsive to their concerns. Approximately one in two surveyed parents of autistic children believe vaccines played a role in their child's autism, often pointing to the vaccines their child received in the first six months of life (Diphtheria, tetanus, pertussis (DTaP), Hepatitis B (HepB), *Haemophilus influenzae* type B (Hib), Poliovirus, inactivated (IPV), and Pneumococcal conjugate (PCV)) and one given at or after the first year of life (Measles, mumps, rubella (MMR)). This connection has not been properly and thoroughly studied by the scientific community.


The five PEPTIDES
I recommend first!
And I take personally!
All prescribed by my
telehealth company!




14
0
1
2
Best Debloat method out
Jack | Fitness & Health · 1-25
Literally a pill can solve the Debloat situation you're in rn #ttshop ... more
Commission paid


GYMSHARK

NEWS FEATURE | 10 June 2025

How to speak to a vaccine sceptic: research reveals what works

Hesitancy about vaccinations is on the rise, but studies show there are specific ways to address people's questions.

By Helen Pearson

Difficult conversations: What the research says works.



Listen, don't judge

Ask what's behind the concern. Dismissing people as ignorant loses them.



Share your view and your reasons

Personal experience of why you vaccinated can be enough for the unsure.



Ask, then inform

Motivational interviewing in Quebec: 76% vs 69% fully vaccinated at 7 months; now province-wide.



Be honest about uncertainty

Overconfident certainty can backfire. Share the weight of evidence.



Choose the messenger

Doctors, faith leaders, people who share their identity are more persuasive than "scientists say."



Know who's persuadable

~2% are firmly anti-vaccine; ~20% are hesitant. Talk to the 20%.

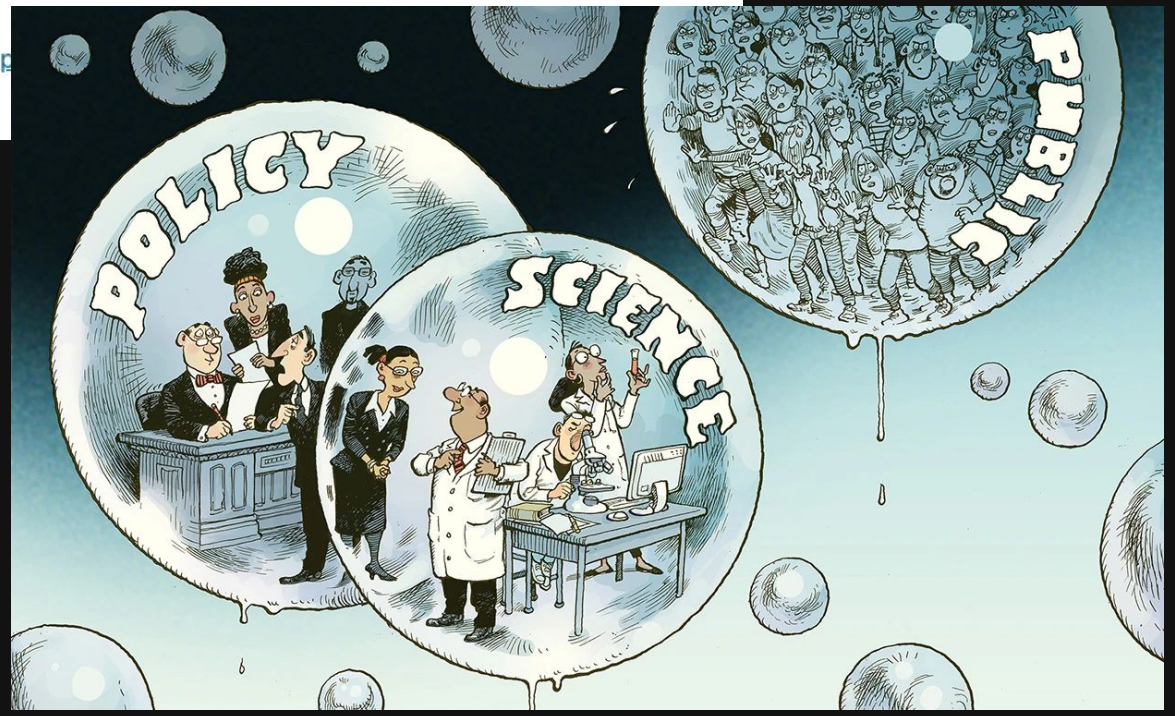
Source: Pearson, "How to speak to a vaccine sceptic: research reveals what works," Nature (2025)

COMMENT | 01 July 2026

Six ways to put the public at the heart of science and policy

Trust in elite institutions is on the wane globally. Building public participation into research and government advice can turn the tide.

By Chris Tyler, K. L. Akerlof, Musa al-Gharbi, Bjørn Bedsted, Laura Boeira, Tracey Brown, Elizabeth Christop
Head, Tepring Piquado & David Budtz Pedersen



What can scientists and institutions do?

Show the work

Publish reasoning and minutes. During COVID, the UK vaccine committee did; the emergency advisory group initially didn’t, and trust suffered.

Name your values

Say when advice rests on a value, e.g. preferring caution over less regulation.

Bring the public in

Citizen panels, consensus conferences, co-designed research. People support advice they helped create.

Serve everyone

Advise governments of every stripe. Authority comes from rigour and willingness to revise, not political affiliation.

Diversify the messengers

People from sceptical groups trust scientists who share their characteristics.

Measure the right thing

Ask whether science lives up to its norms, not just “do you trust science?”

Sources: Tyler et al., “Six ways to put the public at the heart of science and policy,” Nature (2026); Druckman et al. (2026); Gauchat, Nature (2026); Editorial, Nature 655, 7 (2026)

Five takeaways

1. Trust in science is high globally and higher than in most institutions, but it is declining.

2. In the US trust in science is polarized by party, and the gap opened before COVID.

3. Distrust is cultivated by political leaders, and scientists can make it worse by mixing values with evidence.

4. The bigger challenge may be influence: people trust those close to them, and on social; media algorithms reward outrage.

5. Changing minds starts with listening, honesty about uncertainty, and the right messenger.

IN CONVERSATION

Pat Egan

Professor of Politics and Public Policy, NYU · Director, Berkley Institute for Civil Discourse & Civic Solutions

5-minute break · conversation begins at 6:45